India. Obviously, this had direct implications for the fate of Assam and even of the Northeast. To that end, he convened meetings of a cross-section of society and led a public agitation that compelled a positive outcome.

Today, we cannot even contemplate the consequences of a different result, leave alone what it could have meant for the conduct of our foreign policy. Mookerjee did in the east what Patel did in the north and the west. In that sense, the India of today is very much their creation.

While there is a larger point that Mookerjee was making with reference to our approach to Pakistan, his specific analysis of the Nehru–Liaquat Pact of 1950 is also relevant even today. Let us not forget that this understanding was the precipitating factor for his resignation. He underlined that the pact tried to ignore the basic implications of an intolerant State; that the declared positions of the Pakistani government undermined any sense of minority security; and that an ultra-communal administration was giving life to these policies.

There is much that Mookerjee had warned about the treatment of minorities that came true in the decades that passed. He perceptively noted that there was a general impression that India and Pakistan have failed to protect their minorities. The fact, however, is the exact opposite. Mookerjee's view was that in some sections of the foreign press, a hostile propaganda has also been carried on. He believed that this was a libel on India and the truth, he felt, had to be made known to everyone who desire to know it. Apparently, some things have not changed in some quarters!

Mookerjee's remarks on the India–Pakistan equation are of greatest long-term relevance. He predicted much of what has gone wrong, not just in the pact but on the broader ties with Pakistan. In that process, he identified the key conceptual shortcomings very clearly, especially that India and Pakistan are made to appear equally guilty, while Pakistan was in fact the aggressor. Moreover, he pointed out that when Pakistan violated agreements, there was no remedy open to India. He, therefore, felt that there must be sanctions built into any understanding, an approach that would have served India well had it been seriously followed. Seven decades after these insights on Pakistan, it is essential that we reflect on the judgement that Mookerjee bequeathed to us.

This is all the more so as the equivalence between India and Pakistan that was so troubling even in the initial years after Independence morphed into a persistent hyphenation. For decades, India and Pakistan were uttered